

San Fairy Ann Cycling Club Newsletter

September 2026

Creator [Lorna Stafford](#)

After such a busy and enjoyable July and August, this month's newsletter starts on a rather sadder note as we remember a much-loved member of our Club.

While this issue carries sadness, plenty is also happening across the Club, with events to look forward to, new activities getting underway, and, as always, lots of opportunities to get involved.

[Join us in a celebration of Martin Phelps: 1959-2026](#)

Below are the heartfelt comments sent to me. Martin will be missed by everyone who knew him.

Remembering Martin:





Martin Phelps passed away suddenly and unexpectedly on Tuesday 8th September 2026. He joined San Fairy Ann in 2020 and became a much-loved member of the Club.

We asked some of Martin's friends and fellow riders to share their memories of him. These are their words.

Steve H

Martin was my first 'friend' at San Fairy Ann. We lived in the same neck of the woods, and I remember clearly the first time we rode home together after an East Malling-based ride. I was surprised at the pace he held, and indeed the pace I could get riding behind someone fast!

We often rode to and from rides together or picked up the train together for rides further afield. We'd share lifts and chat. We'd sometimes go to the local pub in Leigh or watch a football match and chat.

We talked a lot about all sorts of things, from cycling to personal stuff. We had a lot of banter, but also some serious talks, and I know from what we discussed what a nice man he was and how much his family meant to him.

I will miss the rides and the chats. We often shared a beer. I was perhaps the more enthusiastic drinker, and this picture, taken on the Club trip to Spain, shows us enjoying the moment, with a bar right next door to the ice cream parlour.

RIP Martin.

Laurence C

I'm gutted to hear about Martin, and I'm finding it difficult to write these words. If it hadn't been for San Fairy Ann and our love of cycling, I would never have met Martin. He was one of the nicest human beings I've ever had the privilege of knowing. I was lucky to spend so much time with Martin, and I will never forget his kind words and support. He only spoke well of people and always offered encouragement... a true gentleman. Whether it was a train or car ride to a distant midweeker ride start, a local cycle ride to the start or even a ride on one of the club trips abroad, he was always there. I will miss him terribly and my journey's to and from the midweek rides will be a lot sadder and lonelier from now on. Meg, his daughter, has asked for any nice stories or pictures of their dad to help them at this sad time.

Charlie B

I knew Martin long before I joined the Club; indeed, he was the reason I signed up!

We worked together for a wealth management business. My team and I often turned to him for his advice on Compliance. He was always patient; we didn't always like the advice, but it was insightful.

On my first Club outings, I always checked whether Martin was going to be riding, because it meant a warm smile and a witty remark.

In fact, before I signed up, I would 'borrow' many of his routes from Strava for the best places to ride, and I loved his wry humour in the titles he gave his posts.

To this day, I still have routes in my Strava called 'Martin's this or that', which means he still rides with me.

Mark L

A good memorial ride for Martin. Wish I could be there to remember what a great guy he was. Always good to be around, seeing the positive side in life and sharing jokes at the coffee stop and en route.

I remember him taking the lead many times, allowing us to draft for miles, and if you dropped back, he would slow down and help pull you back to the group, always happy to help you out.

Martin was one of those inspiring people you feel lucky to have met in life.

Russell C

Martin was a stalwart of our MW group, always the first to offer a lead on our future rides.

An inspiration to us all, a really great guy. We will miss him dearly.

Rob W

One of life's good guys; it was always a pleasure to ride with Martin.

Jeremy R

After the very sad news we've had recently, I'd like to include a particular segment that Martin and I absolutely loved riding together. 😊

I have such a lovely memory of us all flying along it with a tailwind and high-fiving afterwards because we'd enjoyed it so much.

Meg, Martin's daughter

This club meant so much to Dad; it gave him space from the hard things at home but, more importantly, so much joy and friendship in a passion he found later in life.

I'm sure you've all heard Dad going on about the hills he climbed. We used to groan at him, but now I miss it.

Steve

Martin meant so much to all of us. We talked about him a lot today, and reflected on how much he'd have enjoyed it, and the look on his face and shake of his head at the pace.

I will miss his friendship and company very much, and I am sure it is the same for many in the Club.

A favourite coffee-stop memory

"I'm sure you're all at your stop at the moment enjoying a coffee and food. He always used to send me photos of the coffee and rate it."

Jill E

Terrible, terrible news. My heart goes out to his poor wife & daughters. 💔 Can't really say anything but, Martin, we will all miss you so much. 💔

Sarah L

I didn't know Martin very well, but I do have some good memories of him. I'm so sorry he's no longer with us.

Richard B

Such sad news. We will all miss Martin.

Thoughts & prayers with all his loved ones.

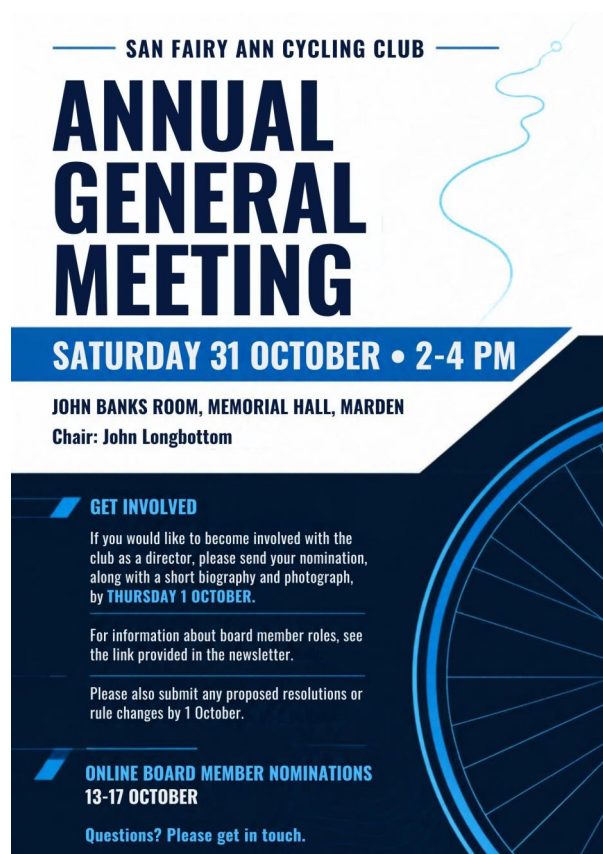
Russell C

Such a shock, so sad. Martin will be so missed by so many.

Phil G

Extremely sad news. Martin will be missed by many.

[Short video, "Let's remember the good times" by Jill Edmunds.](#)

The poster is for the San Fairy Ann Cycling Club's Annual General Meeting. It features a dark blue background with a large, stylized white and light blue graphic of a bicycle wheel on the right side. The text is primarily in white and light blue. At the top, it says 'SAN FAIRY ANN CYCLING CLUB' in a small, sans-serif font. Below this, 'ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING' is written in large, bold, white capital letters. A light blue wavy line graphic is positioned to the right of the title. A dark blue horizontal bar contains the date and time 'SATURDAY 31 OCTOBER • 2-4 PM' in white. Below this bar, the location 'JOHN BANKS ROOM, MEMORIAL HALL, MARDEN' and the chair 'Chair: John Longbottom' are listed in white. The bottom section is titled 'GET INVOLVED' in white, followed by instructions for nominations and resolutions. A final section titled 'ONLINE BOARD MEMBER NOMINATIONS' specifies the dates '13-17 OCTOBER' and includes a contact instruction.

SAN FAIRY ANN CYCLING CLUB

ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

SATURDAY 31 OCTOBER • 2-4 PM

JOHN BANKS ROOM, MEMORIAL HALL, MARDEN
Chair: John Longbottom

GET INVOLVED

If you would like to become involved with the club as a director, please send your nomination, along with a short biography and photograph, by **THURSDAY 1 OCTOBER**.

For information about board member roles, see the link provided in the newsletter.

Please also submit any proposed resolutions or rule changes by 1 October.

ONLINE BOARD MEMBER NOMINATIONS
13-17 OCTOBER

Questions? Please get in touch.

Reminder! Jenny Burton's Great Idea!

And here it is.....

This happens on the 2nd Wednesday of every month at 7.30 pm, starting in October.

14th October 🏆 11th November 🏆 9th December 🏆

The Bull PH, Boxley Road, Penenden Heath, Maidstone, ME14 2DH

We've reserved a private room to the left of the main bar.

So, if you are in one of the SFA teams, this is the perfect space to discuss tactics! And maybe get a few more to join your group!

See you there!

NEW CLUB EVENING MEET UP!

Everyone welcome!
A chance to connect, chat, plan and enjoy good company.

A DATE FOR YOUR DIARIES!

Going back in time when life wasn't so busy... well, not everyone. Some of us don't have the luxury of friends and family and with other people being so busy, it can be difficult to even find someone to have a coffee with.
So our lovely Jenny Burton has come up with an idea...

We will have a **CLUB WIDE MEET UP** once a month, at a pub - they serve coffee, so **NO EXCUSE!**

♥ An opportunity for the various Club race teams to get together, chat tactics and training.
♥ And for others to chat about anything they want, maybe organise a few of them on a cycling trip or whatever.
Come and stick your head round the door and see what you think!

Good chat
Great coffee
Brilliant company.
That's what we're about!

**COME FOR COFFEE, STAY FOR THE CHAT...
YOU'LL BE GLAD YOU DID!**

GOOD PEOPLE ♥ GREAT COFFEE ♥ BIG SMILES ♥ STRONGER TOGETHER

Can We Keep a 100-Year Tradition Going?



For more than 100 years, one of the traditions of San Fairy Ann Cycling Club has been our Birthday Presentations, where we celebrate our members' achievements and recognise those who have earned trophies throughout the year.

But now, we have a problem.

These presentations don't organise themselves. Trophies need collecting, checking, engraving, sorting and handing out, and the whole thing needs a few people willing to give up a little of their time to make it happen.

Right now, we simply don't have enough volunteers. Out of the last 10 new members, only 2 have offered to help.

It would be a real shame if, after more than a century, we had to stop one of the Club's longest-standing traditions because not enough people are willing to help.

And this isn't about asking the same handful of people to do even more. Quite the opposite. The Club belongs to all of us, and traditions only survive when members are willing to play their part.

You don't need specialist knowledge, and you don't need to commit a huge amount of time. Even a short stint of help would make a difference.

So, if you've never volunteered before, this may be the year to give it a go.

Please don't assume that someone else will step forward. That's how we can end up losing something that has been part of **San Fairy Ann for over 100 years**. Ideally, we would like to have a list of volunteers. When we have an event, we can WA everyone in the group, and if you can spare some time, you can let us know.

YOU DO NOT HAVE TO DO A WHOLE SESSION, OR COMMIT TO EVERY WEEK.

If you can spare some time to help with one or more of the following, please let us know. We'd really like to keep this tradition and our other events going.

- **Sportive, TT support, Racing support, Birthday party, Audax, Ride coordinators, Ladies events, Gravel rides. Contact Lorna Stafford via WA.**

Calling All Trackies



Track Riders – October Session

It's not too late to book your place for our next club track session on **24 October**.

You can now book your place via the club website:

[TRACK BOOKING](#)

Autumn Audax Update



1 - 200km



2 - Quick rest



3 - Slight delay

The Fairies Autumn Rides out of Chart Sutton village hall had 71 entries and 57 finishers. This was similar to previous years except that the number of Club members rises each year - more than half this time. Two of the events, the 100 and the 150km, were nominated as 50:50@50 by Audax UK, to encourage more women to take part. And I am delighted to say that across these two events, more than half of the finishers were women: 15 out of 28. Let's hear it for the ladies!

In dry, warm, calm conditions, the 200km riders took a trip to the seaside at Pevensey Bay for a second breakfast after the lumpy section, before heading cross-country on less-trafficked lanes to the Hub Cafe in Wye, which all three distances used as their final catered control. The 150km riders also enjoyed quiet lanes with perhaps fewer hills and more woods before stopping in Battle for their elevenses. The 100km riders were on more familiar lanes through Tenterden.

The fastest riders were very fast - inside 8 hours for the 200km despite the backroads route - and arrived at the finish sweating. Most of the later riders arrived smiling. And they had much to smile about with the perfect weather and rural routes.

Many thanks to David Winslade, who manned the kitchen throughout the afternoon and evening, and to Liz Watts, whose home-made soups were well appreciated.

Bob Watts

TOUR O THE BORDERS 2026



4 - A bit damp then?



5 - View, what view?



6 - Success, Wendy and Jim made it!

“Le Touro” is a closed road event taking place in the Scottish Borders, commencing in Peebles and taking a circular route of 120Km [1200m ascent], including some aptly named “hills”.

The two routes on offer are defined not as “long” or “short”, but advertised as the “Full” route with the option to enter the route identified as “The Challenge”. It may be shorter at 88 km [940 m ascent], but the title strongly hints at the differences.

After our foray into Scottish riding earlier in the year with the Loch Ness Etape, and encouraged by fellow SFACC friends, Wendy and I decided to return for the second closed-road event. As an official partner of Tour de 4, we have close ties, and sponsorship is

encouraged to support Chris Hoy's ambition to raise public awareness of Stage 4 cancer. Tour de 4 aims to bring a community together, offering different rides to suit health and ability, whereas Le Touro is for more experienced cyclists and those looking for a challenging route. They occur on the same day, and it is seen as a very special day for Scottish Road cycling.

The following describes the routes:

"The full route takes in the wilds of the upper Tweed basin, passing the source of the River Tweed and up to the legendary views and savage scenery of the Devil's Beeftub. The descent from here to lovely Moffat town is a huge, mellow, swooping classic. After a neutral zone within Moffat (stop for a quick snack or coffee if you want; the timing pause allows for a short break), you head north again and through one of Scotland's most stunning landscapes – the famous glacial valley of Moffat Dale. An undulating ribbon of tarmac passes wild glens, imposing mountain landscapes and the famous Grey Mare's Tail waterfall.

A cracker of a climb at the end of this valley takes you to a col, the regional boundary and the start of a long and lovely descent to St Mary's Loch.

The route then rejoins with the 88km course, heading for The Gordon Arms, up Paddy Slacks climb and over the pass to Traquair, before heading west along the final kms to Peebles.

The 88km Challenge takes riders up one of Scotland's most celebrated climbs – the mighty Wall of Talla – before crossing wild landscapes to Megget and a stunning traverse beside the water. The long descent continues to St Mary's Loch where the two routes merge for the return leg to Peebles."

Sounds marvellous – doesn't it.

Well, Wendy and I started at some awful time in the morning – thankfully dry and warm. The first few miles were great, and only after the first food station, when we were expecting to see "legendary views" and "savage scenery", did things begin to decline.

The clouds descended, the mist grew wet, and then came rain and a vicious headwind. Views were limited to the cyclist in front – in my case, Wendy. When we arrived in Moffat [halfway point], it looked like a scene from an American movie about hurricane survivors! Bicycles and cyclists were strewn everywhere. The Village Hall that was our sanctuary was awash in a very large pool of water – cyclists were wringing out clothing..... and then the tea ran out! As compensation, they offered me their speciality: macaroni cheese pie! I am sure it was good, but I needed something else.

On the positive side, as soon as we left Moffat, the clouds cleared, it warmed up, and we could enjoy the most amazing scenery, great undulating roads, and the pleasure of being on closed roads. It was simply fabulous.

We arrived in Peebles recording a 5:00:17 time with an average speed of 14.9mph – which, all things considered, was a miracle!

In summary, it was great fun – you can never predict Scottish weather, and we simply experienced it. The route is fabulous - we drove both routes the following day just to see the stunning views.

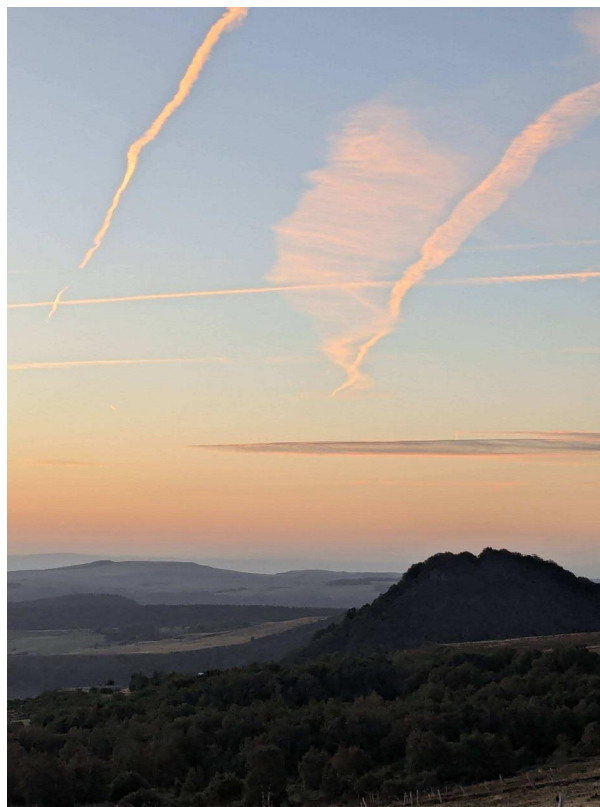
Postscript: Wendy and I then decided to climb the Grey Mare's Tail. It is a route up the side of an amazing waterfall leading to a stunning Loch. You guessed it – we got drenched!

by Jim Lee

Les Volcans d'Auvergne



7 - Bob Watts







Les Volcans d'Auvergne is a UNESCO World Heritage site and an area I had barely explored by bike, so we chose it for our mid-September 2026 tour. Cycling down over five days from the Caen ferry worked well too, starting on the first day with 100 miles on a smooth, traffic-free voie verte cycle path mostly along old railway lines. From this gentle beginning the country got hillier and emptier, especially after crossing the Loire at Tours and leaving the grand chateaux behind. And the anticipation of arriving in the Massif Central rose.

In the spa town of Le Mont Dore, where we had booked a house for a week, I met Club members Warren Martins and Duncan Edwards who had driven down. We enjoyed seven days of rides in all directions from our base near the source of the Dordogne at 1050m. Despite this altitude, every ride started with a warming ascent and ended with a relaxing

descent. Rides included morning coffee and a longish lunch – as they should on any French holiday – despite those traditional cafes becoming more difficult to find.

The queen stage was a 190km loop over Pas de Payrol with 3,400m of ascent and a remarkable 40km descent from the top. Watching the sun come up at the top of the first pass was a highlight, and getting back before sunset was a bonus.

Mid-September was such a good choice, after the holiday scrum but still with brilliant sunshine. We felt the change from enveloping summer warmth to cooler autumn mornings with dew and valley mist.

Over the week we ascended an Everest-and-a-half and covered 750km on smooth roads with those delightful, beautifully graded ascents at 4 or 5%. The ride down there was about the same distance again.

I really recommend this area for touring.

Bob Watts

IT'S GRAVEL TIME! SFA Ladies, Give Gravel a Go!





As all the SFA Ladies know, I'm passionate about giving our ladies the opportunity to try different cycling disciplines. So, when I overheard a couple of them chatting about gravel riding, I thought it would be a great idea to get a group together and give it a go.

Unfortunately, I couldn't find any of our ladies with enough gravel experience to lead a group, so I approached the leader of the lads' group, Jeremy Roth, who very kindly volunteered to take a group of ladies out at Bedgebury Pinetum on a Sunday morning.

It was a beautiful day, and a couple of the ladies hired bikes at Bedgebury, which was the perfect way to try it without spending a fortune on a gravel bike before knowing whether you'll actually enjoy it!

Well, judging by the photos, I think we can safely say they **LOVED IT!**

A second session has already been arranged, and hopefully even more ladies will come along next time. Who knows, we might soon be adding regular **SFA Ladies Gravel Rides** to the club calendar! Thank you for volunteering your time and expertise Jeremy.

SFA APP



8 - Fairies Little Helper

Fairies Little Helper

If you don't already know, one of our members, **Mark Phillipson**, created an app that gives you quick, easy access to all the information on the Club website.

It's called **Fairies Little Helper**, and you can find all the download instructions here: [Home - FairiesLittleHelper](#)

We'd like to say a big **thank you to Mark for giving his time and skills to create something that makes life easier for other Club members.** It's a great example of how a little time given by one member can benefit the whole Club.

Online First Aid Course (with certificate)

The Club still has a few 1st Aid courses that we have paid for. If you are interested in doing the online course. Contact Tony Palmer.

Tony Palmer - Training & Safety - 07786 393838

A little reminder about the ride polls



If you're planning to come on a club ride, please put yourself on the poll, even if you're not 100% certain. If something crops up on the day, you can always take yourself off. It really does make a difference. Without an accurate idea of numbers, our ride leaders are left trying to arrange extra leaders at short notice, and cafes need to be booked without knowing how many people are actually coming.

So please, if you're thinking of riding, put your name on the poll. It takes seconds, and it makes a big difference to the volunteers organising the ride.

Fairies Pay Our Respects.



I'm sure you will all have heard the shocking news of two cyclists, Steve and Natasha, who were tragically killed in the early hours of a quiet Sunday morning in Sole Street, Gravesend, while training for a charity ride. The SFA D Group stopped at the scene to pay their respects and remember them.

 **SFA Christmas Party – Friday 27th November**

This year's Christmas Party is getting a makeover! Steve Harmer is shaking things up, and we're heading to the **Ridge Golf Club, Chartway Street, Maidstone**, on Friday 27th November for what promises to be a great evening with friends, food and a few drinks.

There's something for everyone when it comes to food, with a choice of a **sit-down three-course Christmas dinner for £29.95 per person**, or a **buffet for just £15 per person**. And, of course, the bar will be open throughout the evening, so there's plenty of opportunity to relax, chat and enjoy the festivities.

It would be brilliant to see a good crowd, so **come along, bring your partner, and make a night of it!**

There's a poll pinned to the **Club WA Announcement board**, so if you're interested, please vote there so we know the numbers. Alternatively, you can simply buy your tickets from the [Club Store](#).

Partners are very welcome.

Looking Good in Club Kit.





When we decided to revamp the Club's kit two years ago, it felt like something of an uphill task. We would see other Kent clubs out on the road, looking smart, united and proud in their Club colours, and we wanted that for SFA too.

Having been going for over 100 years, it's fair to say that the Club has changed its kit a few times over the years. Fashion moves on, styles change, and every so often it's time to give things a fresh, modern look.

Two years on, it's fantastic to see just how far we've come. More and more members are choosing to wear the kit, and when you see a group of SFA riders together, all proudly wearing the same colours, it really does make an impact.

We are incredibly proud of the members who have taken the time, effort and expense to invest in their Club kit. **Just look at these photos!** You can't help but feel proud of what we've achieved in such a short time.

Of course, we still have a few members who haven't been tempted into the world of Club colours. Perhaps seeing these photos will finally persuade a few more to join us!

Welcome to SFA.

STUART HOWARD

KEVIN BATTELL

JEREMY PAGE

PAUL BELLAMY

JASON HUTTON

TERRY d'AVRINCOURT

Member Contributions

Here's a version that keeps the friendly tone while adding the practical requests:

A Reminder!

This newsletter is at its best when it includes **your** stories, not just mine.

If you've:

 Been on a club ride

☕ Discovered a great café (or a terrible one...)

📍 Found a cracking route

📷 Taken some photos worth sharing

...then please send it in!

It doesn't have to be polished or poetic—a few lines are plenty. I can tidy it up if needed (that's my superpower).

One small favour: please send **the text and photos as separate files**, rather than as a finished page or layout. It makes it much easier for me to copy, edit and fit everything into the newsletter.

Also, please tell me **who's in the photos**, using **first and last names**, so I can give everyone the credit they deserve.

If you rode it, ate it, broke it, fixed it, or laughed about it afterwards, we'd love to hear about it.

Sharing is caring... and it saves me from having to make things up. 😊

Please send your articles and photos to Lorna via WhatsApp or email at membership@sanfairyancc.co.uk.

Club Contacts

Richard Valentine - President 07505 262465

Duncan Edwards - Chair 07402 549927

Jonathan Engwell - Finance 07801 014877

Jonathan Leeson - Information Technology & Racing Team Lead - 07713 318186

Lorna Stafford - Membership & Events 07790 017482

Stephen Harmer - Events/Club Trips 07539 324565

Linton Schwarz - Club Kit 07901 851707

Emma Tuffey Director Of Club Runs & Events - 07976 262260

Jenny Burton - Club Welfare Officer - 07780 678201

Bob Watts - Sportives & Audax - bobwatts999@gmail.com

Veronica Harmer - Club Secretary & Events - 07910 265061

Tony Palmer - Training & Safety - 07786 393838